Chapter Fifty-Seven

The Wars of Edward I

Between 1275 and 1299,
Edward I of England claims Wales,
the Scots fight for independence,
and Philip IV of France
spends too much money on war

In 1275, Edward of England—aged thirty-six, in the third year of his reign—marched west to conquer the Prince of Wales.

Unlike Scotland, Wales had never possessed a High King who could boast the allegiance of the whole country. Instead, it had rivaling princes who claimed to rule one or more of a handful of small kingdoms: Gwynedd and Powys, Dyfed and Deheubarth, Morgannwg and Ceredigion. This made Wales vulnerable to the English kings, should they choose to push west past Offa's Dyke, the border between Powys and the English county of Mercia. In 1247, Edward's father Henry III had done just that. He had taken the northern territory known as the Perfeddwlad away from the Kingdom of Gwynedd and had then granted the Perfeddwlad to Edward, the crown prince, as his own particular possession.[1]

At the time, the Kingdom of Gwynedd was temporarily leaderless; its prince had died without an heir, and his brother's four sons were fighting over the principality. By 1255, the second brother, Llywelyn ap Gruffudd, had managed to come out on top. But the victory gave him a shrunken Kingdom